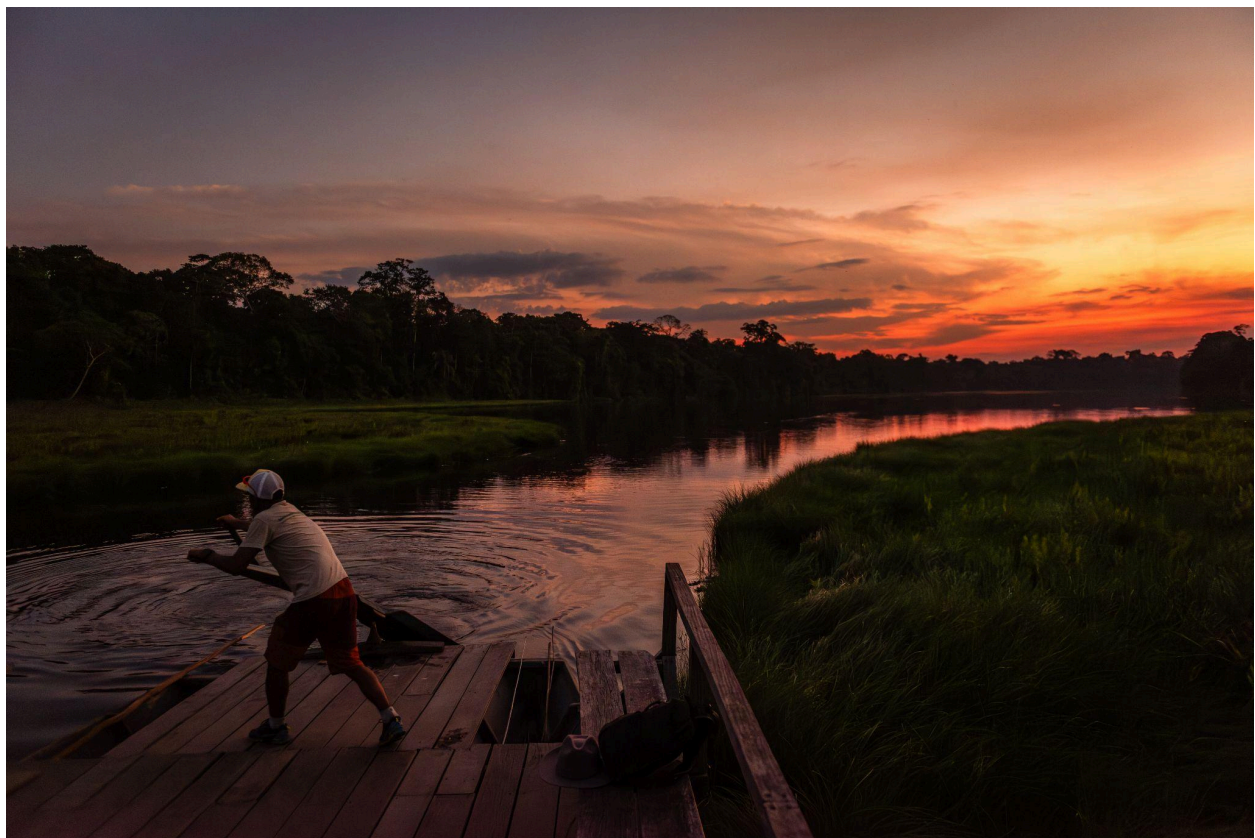


Tres Chimbadas was formed when an ancient river changed its course. Unlike the murky river, the lake water is clear as glass. Several paddle boats rested by the dock. Our guide proudly explained that their design was borrowed from China. He then taught me how to maneuver the heavy oar using only two fingers. Once I found the balance point, the boat glided across the water as light as a feather.

At sunset, the lake and sky turned the same shade of rosé. The oar stirred the colored light into ripples, and the silence around us felt almost sacred. In that moment, I felt myself melt seamlessly into nature. On the return trip, night settled in. Our guide switched off his flashlight, forcing us to sense the rainforest with everything except sight. Sounds from both riverbanks grew instantly louder; the air carried a faint, fishy smell—the passing scent of a reptile. That primal sharpness, that sudden awareness, felt like waking up a forgotten part of myself.



On our final evening in the Amazon, we climbed to a hilltop to watch the sunset. The sky burned red, and the crowns of balsa trees glowed in the fading light like soft clouds. Their fluffy seeds trembled gently, each one like a tiny hope waiting for the wind to carry it onward. Having once held those velvet-soft seeds in my hand, I felt as if I were touching the path of life itself.

